PSYCHOLOGICAL/COGNITIVE FALSE BELIEF #2 · TRUSTING OTHERS · SUSPICION OF MOTIVES

"Friendliness usually hides an ulterior motive."

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Are you having problems accepting help from friends or significant others in your life? Do you tend to mistrust their motives or positive intentions? The information below is intended to help you take a step toward trusting the helpful words or actions given by friends, spouses, or others. The objective is to accept the fact that at least some friendly advice can be a positive influence in your life, and is consistent with God's word as revealed in the Bible.

Where it often comes from

Past manipulation, broken promises, betrayal, or inconsistent care may teach a person to question friendly behavior. These experiences can make caution understandable. But the mind may start treating a possible motive as a proven motive—even when someone is simply being kind.

How the belief can keep itself going

When friendliness is seen as a trap, a person may pull away, question compliments, or test others. A guarded response can make interactions tense, leaving fewer chances to discover genuine care. A better approach is to observe behavior over time and use reasonable boundaries.

What Scripture teaches

Scripture encourages wisdom and careful listening, but also love, hope, and attention to what is true. Trusting God does not require blind trust in every person. It allows us to examine evidence without assuming that all kindness is dishonest.

> *"Trust in the LORD with all your heart, and lean not on your own understanding; in all your ways acknowledge Him, and He will make your paths straight." (Proverbs 3:5–6)*

Also see

> "It bears all things, believes all things, hopes all things, endures all things." (1 Corinthians 13:7)

> "Finally, brothers, whatever is true, whatever is honorable, whatever is right, whatever is pure, whatever is lovely, whatever is admirable—if anything is excellent or praiseworthy—think on these things." (Philippians 4:8)

> "My beloved brothers, understand this: Everyone should be quick to listen, slow to speak, and slow to anger," (James 1:19)

> "He who answers a matter before he hears it—this is folly and disgrace to him." (Proverbs 18:13)

Common self-statements

- They're being nice because they want something.
- No one is friendly without a reason.
- A compliment is probably a trap.
- If I accept help, I'll owe them.
- I need to figure out what they really want.

- People only pretend to care.

Common logical errors

- Mind reading: Assuming you know a person's hidden intentions.
- Jumping to conclusions: Deciding friendliness is manipulation without enough evidence.
- Overgeneralization: Treating some past dishonest people as proof about everyone.
- Confirmation bias: Remembering suspicious moments and discounting genuine kindness.
- Emotional reasoning: Mistaking a feeling of distrust for proof of danger.
- All-or-nothing thinking: Assuming kindness must be completely sincere or completely fake.

Challenging questions

- What did this person actually say or do?
- What evidence suggests an ulterior motive? What evidence does not?
- Could ordinary kindness explain the same behavior?
- Am I judging this person by someone else's past actions?
- Has this person respected a boundary or accepted a 'no'?
- What would a balanced, cautious interpretation sound like?
- What small response would let me learn more without risking too much?

Truth summary

Some people may have selfish motives, but many acts of friendliness are genuine. I can respond with courtesy, observe patterns, and maintain appropriate boundaries. I do not need to assume the worst before I have evidence. I can ask God for wisdom and choose a measured response.

Related Pearls topics

Open these topics in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Trust
- Protection
- Friendship
- Love, For Others
- Fear

Godly Counsel Lessons — read or print:

- Anxiety/Worry/Fear
- Communication
- Thinking, Healthy

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

> Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes
>
> Your browser cannot play this audio.

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Click a picture to play inside this card. A YouTube link is provided as a fallback.

The Same Love
Paul Baloche

Reflect on love that welcomes and restores, rather than assuming every caring gesture conceals a selfish motive.

Goodness of God
CeCe Winans

Rehearse examples of faithful goodness instead of attending only to possible betrayal.

No Longer Slaves
Jonathan David & Melissa Helser

Let assurance of belonging to God loosen the fear that turns ordinary kindness into a perceived threat.

Trust in God
Elevation Worship feat. Chris Brown

Practice resting in God's faithfulness while remaining open to receiving sincere care from others.

Official lyric videos with words on screen. Songs play inside the card; YouTube may show ads.

Clinical background

For counselors: beliefs like this are often discussed in connection with what clinicians call paranoid personality disorder. This educational example uses CBT methods: checking evidence, generating alternative interpretations, and trying low-risk behavioral experiments. Suspiciousness may be associated with paranoid personality patterns, but a single belief is not a diagnostic test. Avoid experiments with people who have threatened, exploited, or abused you.

Beck Institute: Personality Belief Questionnaire materials · Beck, Davis, & Freeman, Cognitive Therapy of Personality Disorders

Each morning ask: "What evidence do I have about this person's motives, and how can I respond wisely today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "Friendliness usually hides an ulterior motive."

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Check one choice in each section or write your own. Choose a question and a truth that feel meaningful to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it from 0% to 100%.

> "Friendliness usually hides an ulterior motive." I believe this _____ %.

2 My best question

Select a question to ask when suspicion appears.

- ☐ What did this person actually say or do?
- ☐ What evidence suggests an ulterior motive? What evidence does not?
- ☐ Could ordinary kindness explain the same behavior?
- ☐ Am I judging this person by someone else's past actions?
- ☐ Has this person respected a boundary or accepted a 'no'?
- ☐ What would a balanced, cautious interpretation sound like?

My own question:

3 My replacement truth

Select a balanced statement to practice.

- ☐ Kindness may be genuine; I can look at the evidence.
- ☐ I do not have to know someone's motives immediately.
- ☐ I can be friendly while keeping sensible boundaries.
- ☐ A compliment does not automatically create an obligation.
- ☐ I can wait for patterns of behavior before deciding.
- ☐ God calls me to wisdom, not constant suspicion.

In my own words:

4 My Scripture

Choose one passage to remember; these are the same passages shown on the card.

- ☐ Proverbs 3:5–6
  "Trust in the LORD with all your heart, and lean not on your own understanding; in all your ways acknowledge Him, and He will make your paths straight."
- ☐ 1 Corinthians 13:7
  "It bears all things, believes all things, hopes all things, endures all things."
- ☐ Philippians 4:8
  "Finally, brothers, whatever is true, whatever is honorable, whatever is right, whatever is pure, whatever is lovely, whatever is admirable—if anything is excellent or praiseworthy—think on these things."

- [ ] James 1:19
  “My beloved brothers, understand this: Everyone should be quick to listen, slow to speak, and slow to anger,”
- [ ] Proverbs 18:13
  “He who answers a matter before he hears it—this is folly and disgrace to him.”

The verse I will practice:

Practicing the Truth

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5 Rehearse the truth daily

Read your chosen Scripture, listen, and practice a balanced thought.

Read Pearls: Trust. Listen to Overcoming Anxiety. Say your replacement truth aloud once in the morning and once in the evening.

Today I noticed this change:

6 Try a small behavioral experiment

Choose a safe, low-risk test; do not ignore real warning signs.

- ☐ When a familiar person offers a small courtesy, say thank you without trying to guess their motive. Later, note what actually happened.
- ☐ Accept a minor, no-strings-attached kindness from someone with a history of respecting your boundaries. Record whether a demand followed.
- ☐ Offer a small kindness to another person with no expectation of repayment. Reflect on how kindness can be genuine.
- ☐ For one week, record both examples of sincere kindness and examples of self-interest. Compare the whole pattern.
- ☐ When someone compliments you, write down three possible explanations—including a sincere one—before deciding.
- ☐ Set a polite boundary ('No, thank you') and notice whether the person respects it. Do not test someone who has been unsafe.

My prediction:

What actually happened:

What I learned:

7 Track what changes

Practice for seven days. Mark what you tried and rate belief strength.

Day	What I practiced	Belief %	What I learned
1			
2			
3			
4			

Day	What I practiced	Belief %	What I learned
5			
6			
7			

Song reflection

After listening to one of the four songs, write a sentence about trusting God and treating people fairly.

Song:

A truth I want to remember:

My Truth Card

OLD BELIEF:
~~Friendliness usually hides an ulterior motive.~~

NEW TRUTH:
I can recognize genuine kindness through evidence and time, while keeping healthy boundaries.

MY SCRIPTURE:
Proverbs 3:5–6

A short prayer

Lord, help me notice what is true instead of assuming what others intend. Give me wisdom to recognize danger, courage to receive sincere kindness, and love that does not rush to judge. Amen.

Scripture quotations: Berean Standard Bible (BSB), public domain. Educational material only; not a diagnosis or substitute for professional care.